

Africa Tourism and Travel in 2026

Executive summary

Africa entered 2026 with tourism in its strongest position since the pandemic shock, but the rebound has been highly uneven across subregions and country types. At the continental level, international arrivals in Africa were already above 2019 by 2024, rose another 9% year over year in the first quarter of 2025, and ended 2025 at about 81 million arrivals, up 8% from 2024 and ahead of every other world region in growth. The recovery has been led by North Africa's scale markets, Southern Africa's diversified nature-and-urban circuits, and parts of East Africa's safari, island, and meetings businesses. ¹

The most important strategic fact is that "Africa tourism" is not one market. It is several. North Africa is dominated by large, aviation-led leisure flows from Europe and the Gulf. East Africa is a premium mix of wildlife, islands, gorilla trekking, and conferences. Southern Africa combines high-volume regional mobility with globally renowned self-drive, safari, wine, and adventure circuits. West Africa remains driven by diaspora, culture, beaches, city breaks, and event tourism. Central Africa is still small in volume, but it has some of the continent's most distinctive under-visited ecotourism assets. ²

Three forces are now shaping the next phase of growth. First, air access, visa facilitation, and route expansion are widening Africa's reachable market: airlines added capacity to cities such as Dakar ³, Accra ⁴, Entebbe ⁵, and Addis Ababa ⁶, while Southern Africa moved to expand the KAZA Univisa concept. Second, hotel brands and investors are moving deeper into secondary African markets, especially in island, business-travel, and safari destinations. Third, the constraints are becoming clearer: environmental carrying capacity, waste, road and utility quality, fragmented destination management, and weak tourism statistics in several states. ⁷

The best-performing destinations are those that combine four things at once: relatively easy air access, clear product identity, strong destination marketing, and enough on-the-ground reliability for visitors to convert interest into bookings. That is why Morocco ⁸, Egypt ⁹, South Africa ¹⁰, Kenya ¹¹, Tanzania ¹², Mauritius ¹³, Tunisia ¹⁴, and Zambia ¹⁵ have gained ground, while places with weaker security, poor transport, or thin public data have grown more slowly even when their tourism assets are world class. ¹⁶

The main policy conclusion is that the next growth frontier is not just "more tourists." It is better yield, stronger local linkages, cleaner destinations, easier movement, and more credible statistics. The countries most likely to outperform over the next three to five years are those that improve visas and border experience, protect natural assets, deepen domestic and regional tourism, strengthen destination management, and make it easier for small operators to sell digitally. ¹⁷

Continental picture and method

As of April 19, 2026, the latest full-year tourism data are a patchwork. Some destinations already have full-year 2025 releases, others have 2024 full-year numbers, and several still lag at 2023 or partial 2025. Cross-

country comparisons therefore need caution: some states count international tourists, some count visitors, some include same-day or land-border flows, and some publicly release only hotel or leisure segments. This report therefore uses the latest openly available official or near-official figure for each market and flags data gaps where needed. ¹⁸

Region	Country	Latest openly available arrivals figure	Year/status	What mainly drives demand
North	Morocco	19.0 million	2025	City breaks, culture, coast, MICE, events
North	Egypt	19.0 million	2025	Antiquities, Red Sea resorts, Nile cruises
North	Tunisia	10.25 million	2024 full year; more than 10.03 million by Nov. 20, 2025	Beach packages, culture, diaspora/regional travel
North	Algeria	3.3 million foreign tourists	2023	Sahara, heritage, diaspora/family visits
East	Kenya	2.394 million	2024	Safari, coast, city/ MICE, diaspora
East	Tanzania	2.142 million	2024	Safari circuit, Zanzibar, climbing, beaches
East	Uganda	1.372 million	2024	Gorilla/chimp/wildlife, regional travel
East	Rwanda	1.36 million	2024	Gorilla trekking, MICE, premium eco-tourism
East	Mauritius	1.436 million	2025	Beach resort holidays, honeymoon, long-stay leisure
East	Seychelles	354,034+	2025 through week 47; already above 2024 full year	High-value island leisure
East	Madagascar	308,275	2024	Biodiversity, adventure, beaches
West	Ghana	1.289 million	2024	Diaspora, history, culture, events
West	Cape Verde	1.248 million guests	2025	Sun-and-beach packages, resort islands

Region	Country	Latest openly available arrivals figure	Year/status	What mainly drives demand
West	The Gambia	232,000	2024/25 season	Winter-sun, birding, beaches
Central	São Tomé and Príncipe	42,000	2025	Boutique island eco-tourism
Southern	South Africa	10.5 million	2025	Cities, wildlife, wine, road trips, beaches
Southern	Namibia	1.444 million foreign arrivals	2024	Self-drive desert and wildlife circuits
Southern	Botswana	1.183 million tourists	2023	Delta/Chobe safari, high-value low-volume
Southern	Zimbabwe	1.6 million+	2024	Victoria Falls, heritage, wildlife
Southern	Zambia	2.200 million	2024	Victoria Falls, safari, meetings, regional circuits
Southern	Mozambique	1.27 million	2025	Coast, islands, city/business, regional leisure
Southern	Angola	863,872 international arrivals; 52,072 leisure visitors	2023 arrivals; 2025 leisure segment	Business travel, emerging leisure

The table aggregates country releases, statistical reports, and official statements; definitions are not fully harmonized across markets. ¹⁹

timeline

title Africa tourism recovery

2019 : Pre-pandemic baseline

2020 : Border closures and collapse in arrivals

2023 : Most African markets in strong rebound phase

2024 : Africa about 74 million arrivals, above 2019

2025 Q1 : Arrivals up 9% year over year, 16% above 2019

2025 FY : Africa about 81 million arrivals, up 8%

The recovery timeline above synthesizes the latest continent-wide releases from UN Tourism ²⁰ and industry reporting on Africa. ¹

Across the continent, the strongest demand drivers are still familiar: wildlife, heritage, beaches, weather, and diaspora. But the fastest-growing overlays are events, meetings, premium experiences, and easier booking through digital channels. Expanded hotel pipelines from major global brands underscore investor confidence, especially in business-leisure hybrids and internationally recognized safari or island markets.

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North Africa

Current status and drivers

North Africa is Africa's volume engine. Morocco and Egypt both crossed roughly 19 million visitors in 2025, while Tunisia remains one of the continent's largest package-and-beach destinations and Algeria is trying to scale up a still-underdeveloped heritage-and-Sahara offer. The core model is clear: short- and medium-haul air access from Europe, warm-weather appeal, large room stock, strong cultural brands, and—especially in Morocco and Egypt—state-backed tourism roadmaps. 22

Morocco's strength is breadth. It can sell medina culture, Atlantic and Mediterranean coasts, mountain landscapes, desert camps, and city-break infrastructure in one package. Egypt's strength is even more concentrated and powerful: the pyramids-and-antiquities brand plus Red Sea year-round resort capacity and Nile cruising. Tunisia competes more on value, repeat Mediterranean demand, and low-friction package travel, while Algeria remains a high-potential but relatively low-conversion market because transport, visas, and service ecosystems still lag its neighbors. 23

Country patterns, products, and traveler experience

For Morocco, the core inbound geography remains heavily linked to European source markets, supported by expanded air routes and aggressive destination promotion. The most internationally visible circuits are Marrakech–Atlas–desert, Fez–Chefchaouen–Tangier, and Casablanca–Rabat–Essaouira. Tourists disproportionately favor riads and boutique hotels in old-city districts for short cultural stays, then shift to chain or resort formats on the coast and in golf/beach zones. Dining demand is split between heritage-medina food experiences and contemporary urban restaurants in major city centers. 24

Egypt's tourism geography is two-track: Cairo/Giza/Luxor/Aswan for cultural tourism, and Hurghada/Sharm el-Sheikh/Marsa Alam for resort-led sun-and-sea tourism. One useful indicator of policy success is how strongly the state has pushed diversification in product and source markets while still leaning on flagship heritage. Germany remained one of the leading inbound markets in 2025, while the opening momentum around the Grand Egyptian Museum added a fresh demand boost. In practical travel terms, Egypt tends to work best when visitors structure movement around flights or organized rail/road transfers rather than trying to improvise long overland links. 25

Tunisia's pattern is more classic Mediterranean package tourism, anchored by beach markets such as Hammamet, Sousse, Monastir, and Djerba, but it also has credible cultural depth in Tunis, Kairouan, El Jem, and southern desert circuits. Its continued scale—10.25 million tourists in 2024 and more than 10 million again by late November 2025—shows that the country still has one of the largest leisure machines on the continent. The tourism ministry's own 2025 benchmarking target of 11 million visitors indicates policy confidence, but the challenge is moving further from a price-led model toward higher-spending and better-dispersed travel. 26

Algeria is best understood as an unrealized destination rather than a failed one. It has Roman sites, major Islamic heritage, coastline, mountains, and Saharan landscapes, yet it hosted only about 3.3 million foreign tourists in 2023, far below its neighbors. That gap is largely structural: visa friction, lower international route density, weaker destination merchandising, and the long shadow of the 1990s security crisis. The upside is that the development runway is long if access and investment improve. ²⁷

Recent public traveler sentiment broadly supports this picture. One traveler returning from Morocco in early 2025 described the country as “magical” and praised how “welcoming” people were, while another said the perceived hassle in Marrakech was “way over blown” if approached with realistic expectations. On Egypt, public travel threads in 2025 repeatedly converged on one operational lesson: Cairo is far smoother with a guide or driver, while Luxor feels more manageable independently. ²⁸

Policy implications and short recommendations

North Africa’s policy challenge is no longer only recovery. It is yield, congestion management, and destination diversification. Morocco and Egypt can grow further, but they need more dispersal beyond flagship icons. Tunisia needs more value capture per arrival. Algeria needs basic enabling reforms before it can compete at the same scale. ²⁹

Short actions follow naturally. Governments should continue route development and visa simplification, but pair them with city-level carrying-capacity management. Tourism bodies should package secondary cities and shoulder seasons more aggressively. Private operators should push multi-stop itineraries that combine heritage with coast or desert, because that raises length of stay and spend. And ministries need to publish more consistent monthly source-market and regional data, especially where public releases are still thin.

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East Africa

Current status and drivers

East Africa is Africa’s most internationally recognizable nature circuit and increasingly its most diversified premium tourism region. Kenya and Tanzania remain the classic safari anchors; Uganda and Rwanda compete in primates and high-value eco-tourism; Mauritius and Seychelles dominate upscale island leisure; Madagascar offers one of the world’s most biologically distinctive adventure products. The region’s growth drivers are wildlife, conservation branding, marine and beach tourism, meetings, and steadily improving air connectivity. ³¹

Kenya welcomed about 2.394 million international visitors in 2024. The top source markets remained the United States, Uganda, Tanzania, the United Kingdom, and India, which is telling: the country succeeds because it combines long-haul safari appeal with dense regional and diaspora-linked travel. Tanzania recorded roughly 2.142 million visitors in 2024 and nearly \$3.9 billion in travel receipts, with wildlife, Zanzibar, and climbing remaining central. Uganda welcomed 1.372 million international visitors in 2024, while Rwanda saw 1.36 million visitors and \$647 million in tourism revenue, with a notable 27% jump in gorilla-tourism revenue. ³²

On the island side, Mauritius reached 1,436,250 arrivals in 2025, up from 1,382,177 in 2024, with France, the United Kingdom, and Réunion still the principal markets. Seychelles crossed its entire 2024 visitor total by

late November 2025, underscoring the resilience of its high-value model, even though volume remains much smaller than Mauritius. Madagascar recorded 308,275 international visitor arrivals in 2024 and was still building upward in 2025, with the state openly targeting much higher medium-term numbers. ³³

Country patterns, products, and traveler experience

Kenya's core tourism grid is Nairobi for gateway and urban services, the Maasai Mara–Amboseli–Laikipia wildlife belt for safari, and the coast around Diani, Watamu, and Lamu for beach and culture. International tourists typically sort themselves into three accommodation bands: all-inclusive safari camps, city business-leisure hotels, and beach resorts or villas. Dining is strongest in Nairobi's premium districts and on the coast's hotel-and-beach restaurant circuit. The country's big advantage is product combinability: a traveler can do wildlife, coast, and city in one trip without changing countries. ³⁴

Recent traveler commentary helps explain why Kenya remains sticky. One solo traveler described a 2025 shoulder-season Mara trip as "peaceful and green" and said, "I felt very safe," while another said a camp stay was "100%" recommended because the guide, vehicle, and accommodation were integrated. That is exactly the region's appeal: the service stack tends to work best when logistics are bundled rather than self-assembled. ³⁵

Tanzania's strongest proposition is the pairing of the northern safari circuit with Zanzibar. The public travel-performance survey shows that holiday visitors, especially from the United States, Italy, and France, remain central to earnings. Tourists generally choose safari lodges and tented camps on the mainland, then shift to boutique hotels in Stone Town or beach resorts on Zanzibar's east and north coasts. This duality gives Tanzania unusually high itinerary flexibility: premium safari, trek-and-safari, honeymoon, diving, or beach recovery after wildlife travel. ³⁶

Uganda and Rwanda both operate higher-yield, lower-volume models. Uganda's strongest assets are gorilla trekking, chimpanzee trekking, Murchison-Queen Elizabeth wildlife circuits, and river-based adventure around the Nile. Rwanda has built an exceptionally coherent brand around gorilla trekking, conservation, and the MICE economy centered on Kigali. In both countries, tourists disproportionately use lodge-based formats, licensed tour operators, and smart regional flight connections rather than fully independent travel. ³⁷

Mauritius and Seychelles are different again. Mauritius is broader and more scalable: larger room stock, stronger family and resort volume, and a diversified mix of beaches, weddings, and long-stay leisure. Seychelles is smaller, pricier, and more exclusive, with Europe still dominant, Germany especially important, and Gulf links valuable at the margin. Both are highly dependent on aviation and destination cleanliness. ³⁸

Madagascar remains one of Africa's most compelling "discovery" destinations. Its recent official messaging emphasizes nature, seaside, and cultural tourism, and the 2024 recovery data confirm a demand base for that narrative. But the operating reality is still rougher than in Mauritius or Seychelles: distance, internal transport, and service consistency can all be limiting. The result is that Madagascar is best positioned for adventurous, itinerary-based travel rather than frictionless mass leisure. ³⁹

Policy implications and short recommendations

East Africa's main strength is product differentiation, but the region still leaves money on the table by under-linking products across borders and by over-relying on a few iconic nodes. More cross-border marketing around "safari + island," better regional visas, and stronger community-revenue mechanisms would all improve resilience. Protected-area quality also matters directly to revenue. Recent work on revenue-sharing and sustainable tourism in the region reinforces that conservation and local benefit are not side issues; they are core to long-run competitiveness. ⁴⁰

The short recommendation set is straightforward: protect carrying capacity in flagship ecosystems; expand reliable regional air links; make bundled cross-border itineraries easier; reduce plastics and waste in island markets; and keep raising the quality of public tourism statistics at monthly frequency. ⁴¹

West Africa

Current status and drivers

West Africa is still not a single easily marketable tourism region, but it has become more dynamic than standard safari-centric narratives suggest. The strongest themes are diaspora return travel, history and memory tourism, beaches, music and nightlife, event calendars, birding, resort islands, and city-based cultural travel. The most clearly performing open-data markets are Ghana, Cape Verde, and The Gambia, while Senegal remains culturally important but statistically less transparent in current public releases. Côte d'Ivoire and Nigeria matter increasingly for business, events, and brand-building, even where leisure conversion remains incomplete. ⁴²

Ghana reached 1,288,804 arrivals in 2024. Its tourism model is unusual by African standards because it mixes diaspora and heritage travel with urban culture and December event demand. Cape Verde hit a record 1,248,052 guests in 2025, driven by European winter-sun demand, low-cost connectivity, and the dominance of Sal and Boa Vista. The Gambia's 2024/25 season climbed to about 232,000 arrivals, helped by restored charter and tour-operator demand from the Baltics and Scandinavia. ⁴³

Country patterns, products, and traveler experience

Ghana's practical tourism geography is Accra as the lifestyle and event center, Cape Coast and Elmina as the history-memory corridor, Kakum and interior eco-sites for short extensions, and beach/leisure spillovers on the coast. The country's growth still reflects the afterlife of the "Year of Return/Beyond the Return" strategy, but 2024 also showed how event tourism can create local price pressure and social tension if destination management lags demand. Accommodation is concentrated in city hotels, short-stay apartments, and a growing upper-midscale lifestyle segment in Accra, with smaller guesthouse and resort stock elsewhere. ⁴⁴

Cape Verde's model is the cleanest in West Africa: island resort concentration, powerful European source markets, and relatively simple packaging. Sal and Boa Vista dominate, hotels captured 85.2% of overnight stays in 2025, and the main source markets were the United Kingdom, Portugal, Germany, France, Belgium, and the Netherlands. That is a highly legible tourism economy, but it is also tourism-dependent enough that climate, waste, and route concentration are macro risks. ⁴⁵

The Gambia remains a compact winter-sun and birding destination. The strongest practical advantages are that it is small, navigable, beach-led, and compatible with river and mangrove excursions. Public traveler commentary reflects that logic closely; one poster described weekends of “surfing or birdwatching” and said the country is “small and easy to travel around,” while another highlighted Kotu beach, cultural sites, and the Senegambia restaurant-bar strip. ⁴⁶

Senegal has one of West Africa’s richest cultural and urban tourism portfolios: Dakar, Gorée, Saint-Louis, Sine-Saloum, Petite Côte, and Casamance. But recent public open-data releases are more fragmented than for some peers, with stronger regional and thematic data than a simple national arrivals dashboard. Traveler commentary suggests the product remains compelling: one visitor said Senegalese were “exceptionally nice” and that they “experienced no crime,” while another described Dakar and Saly as enjoyable though somewhat more commercially insistent than smaller places such as Popenguine. That mix—warmth, culture, complexity, and uneven tourism polish—is central to Senegal’s current positioning. ⁴⁷

Côte d’Ivoire has pursued a different route: destination branding through the “Sublime Côte d’Ivoire” strategy, major events including AFCON 2024 spillovers, and international sports-marketing partnerships such as the one with Olympique de Marseille. This is a high-visibility strategy, but public statistical transparency still lags marketing ambition. The country’s likely medium-term promise is strongest in Abidjan city breaks, meetings, domestic upscale leisure, and selected heritage/coastal nodes if circuits become easier to book. ⁴⁸

Nigeria is the region’s giant in cultural energy but not yet in international leisure conversion. Public reporting indicates only about 1.2 million visitors in 2023, despite enormous product potential. Security perceptions, infrastructure deficits, weak destination packaging, and limited service consistency remain binding constraints, though urban event travel—especially in Lagos—has been more successful than nationwide leisure branding. ⁴⁹

Policy implications and short recommendations

West Africa’s strongest tourism advantage is culture, but culture-led growth needs better logistics. The region would benefit more than almost any other African subregion from easier intra-regional movement, better roads on heritage corridors, and more reliable destination information in English and French. The countries most likely to outperform are those that turn festivals and diaspora traffic into repeat visitation outside the peak season. ⁵⁰

The immediate priorities are to professionalize destination management around events, publish better monthly tourism data, reduce price shocks during peak periods, and invest in bookable circuits rather than one-off promotion campaigns. In practical travel terms, West Africa is selling emotion and culture very well; it still needs to sell ease. ⁵¹

Central Africa

Current status and drivers

Central Africa is the weakest tourism data environment on the continent and also, paradoxically, one of the most under-valued from a product perspective. The region has rainforests, primates, Atlantic islands, national parks, and some of Africa’s most distinctive small-state ecotourism possibilities, but volume is low

and many markets remain dominated by business, official, or visiting-friends-and-relatives travel rather than broad leisure demand. The clearest current success case is São Tomé and Príncipe, which reached a new record of 42,000 visitors in 2025 and is explicitly targeting 50,000 by 2030. ⁵²

Open-data visibility is much thinner elsewhere. Cameroon's last official-type benchmark visible in widely used international datasets was just over 1 million arrivals in 2019, while later market estimates suggest a gradual rebound. For Gabon, Congo, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, publicly accessible tourism statistics are patchier still, and that itself is an investment barrier because it makes benchmarking and planning harder. In these markets, the "data gap" is not a minor technical issue; it is a core competitiveness problem. ⁵³

Country patterns, products, and traveler experience

São Tomé and Príncipe has the clearest leisure proposition: boutique island eco-tourism, beaches, rainforests, cacao heritage, diving, and a very low-density visitor experience. Public traveler sentiment is consistent on that point. Recent posts described it as "stunningly beautiful," "wild, remote and exotic," which is exactly the comparative advantage the islands should keep protecting. The flip side is that remoteness, limited room stock, and thin transport networks mean it should not chase volume for its own sake. ⁵⁴

Cameroon has a far broader product base than its current tourism profile suggests: mountain landscapes, wildlife, coast, and francophone-anglophone culinary and cultural variety. But the country has not yet translated that breadth into a strong internationally merchandised leisure circuit. Similar logic applies, in different ways, to Gabon and the Republic of the Congo, where rainforest and conservation assets are strong but tourism ecosystems remain narrow. ⁵⁵

From a travel-planning perspective, Central Africa is therefore best thought of as a specialist market. Tourists who go tend to be more exploratory, use operators more heavily, accept more logistical uncertainty, and place a premium on nature and novelty. That is commercially viable, but only if safety, permits, transfers, and room supply are tightly managed. ⁵⁶

Policy implications and short recommendations

The first recommendation in Central Africa is brutally simple: publish credible tourism data. Without consistent official monthly or annual releases, destinations become harder to finance, harder to market, and harder to compare. The second is connectivity. For the region's smaller markets, one or two better air links can matter more than large ad campaigns. The third is a quality-over-quantity strategy: ecotourism, scientific travel, island escapes, and premium niche circuits are more realistic than mass package tourism in the medium term. ⁵⁷

Southern Africa

Current status and drivers

Southern Africa is the continent's most complete multi-country tourism system: urban gateways, self-drive deserts, iconic wildlife, wine regions, waterfalls, beaches, and relatively strong regional road-air integration. South Africa regained genuine scale and reached a record 10.5 million international arrivals in 2025.

Namibia, Botswana, Zimbabwe, and Zambia all sit inside a highly complementary landscape economy, while Mozambique and Angola add coastlines and business-leisure diversification. ⁵⁸

The regional demand structure is mixed. South Africa is still heavily fed by the African continent itself, which supplied 6.8 million arrivals in 2024. Botswana's tourists are overwhelmingly regional, with the SADC subregion accounting for 77.2% in 2023 and South Africa alone contributing 394,090 tourists. Namibia also relies strongly on neighboring African markets while retaining an important German and European self-drive segment. That mix matters because it makes Southern Africa more resilient than destinations dependent on a single long-haul source region. ⁵⁹

Country patterns, products, and traveler experience

South Africa remains unmatched in Africa for breadth: Cape Town and the Winelands, Kruger and private reserves, the Garden Route, Durban coast, Johannesburg/Pretoria business travel, and meetings infrastructure. Official monthly analysis shows 2025 growth was broad-based and especially strong from Africa and Europe. One reason the country keeps converting visitors is product stacking: city, food, wine, coast, and wildlife all fit into a single trip. The main friction remains urban security perception, which makes visitor information and transport reliability especially important. ⁶⁰

Namibia has become one of Africa's most distinctive self-drive markets. The 2024 foreign-arrivals jump to 1,444,174 confirms recovery, but the qualitative brand story matters just as much: vast landscapes, low-density roads, desert-plus-wildlife circuits, and unusually strong independence for travelers who are comfortable driving. Public traveler commentary is remarkably consistent: recent posters called it "one of the best self-drive destinations in the world" and "incredibly beautiful," while also warning that off-road conditions and remote stretches require preparation and that night driving should be avoided. ⁶¹

Botswana's tourism model is deliberately high-value, low-volume. The Okavango Delta and Chobe remain the anchors, often sold in tandem with Victoria Falls. Official statistics show 1,183,432 tourists in 2023, but only 26.4% were holiday/leisure tourists; a large share is regional and transit-linked. In market terms, Botswana works best at the premium end and often functions as part of a wider Southern African circuit rather than a standalone mass destination. Travelers repeatedly describe the Okavango as "magical" and "an amazing experience," which is exactly why the country has been able to sustain a relatively price-heavy conservation model. ⁶²

Zimbabwe and Zambia are best understood together around Victoria Falls, though each has wider product depth. Zimbabwe reported more than 1.6 million international arrivals and about \$1.2 billion in receipts in 2024. Zambia reached about 2.2 million international arrivals in 2024 and was already at 2 million by October 2025, on course to exceed 2.4 million. Zambia's growth narrative is especially connected to policy reforms, marketing to India, China, and the Gulf, and stronger MICE and air-access efforts. The operational challenge on the Zimbabwe side remains infrastructure quality; public traveler commentary in 2025 still praised the destination itself while complaining sharply about roads. ⁶³

Mozambique and Angola are more mixed stories. Mozambique reached about 1.27 million tourists in 2025 despite a difficult political context and has a strong medium-term case in coast-and-island leisure, especially if road security and investment quality improve. Angola is still more business-oriented than leisure-oriented, but the state is clearly trying to shift that balance: it reported 863,872 international arrivals in 2023 and a

20% rise in leisure arrivals in 2025 to 52,072. These remain early-stage numbers in leisure terms, but they indicate a policy pivot worth watching. ⁶⁴

A major structural opportunity for the whole subregion is easier multi-country travel. The effort to expand the KAZA Univisa beyond the existing Zambia-Zimbabwe framework is exactly the kind of practical integration Southern Africa needs, because its product logic is already regional even when policy is still national. ⁶⁵

Policy implications and short recommendations

Southern Africa's priority is to make an already excellent product easier and greener. The region should move faster on common-visa or corridor facilitation, repair key approach roads to flagship destinations, and protect wildlife corridors from overdevelopment. Where new high-end inventory is planned, approval processes should explicitly test ecological carrying capacity and community benefit-sharing rather than just room-count growth. ⁶⁶

Pan-African implications, investment outlook, and annotated bibliography

Across Africa, tourism is now moving from “recovery mode” to “quality of growth mode.” The decisive winners over the next five years are likely to be destinations that improve five things simultaneously: air access, visas, destination management, environmental quality, and statistical credibility. Brand-building alone is no longer enough; tourists increasingly compare bookability, reliability, and cleanliness across destinations in real time. ⁶⁷

The investment picture is encouraging but selective. Global hotel chains are expanding in African markets because they see sustained demand growth, especially in mixed business-leisure gateways, islands, and safari circuits. But high-performing destinations will be the ones that protect the underlying asset. Plastic waste, unchecked lodge expansion, weak community linkages, and overloaded urban heritage centers can all erode long-run competitiveness surprisingly quickly. ⁶⁸

The clearest continent-wide recommendations are therefore practical. Governments should harmonize tourism statistics to UN standards and publish them monthly. They should simplify visas, scale regional visa schemes, and make airports and land borders less unpredictable. Tourism boards should market longer, multi-stop itineraries rather than single-site icons. Investors should focus on service reliability, waste management, and community benefit, not just room growth. And development partners should treat tourism as an export sector linked to conservation, infrastructure, and small-enterprise digitalization—not only as a branding exercise. ⁶⁹

Data gaps remain significant. Full-year 2025 figures are still unavailable or incomplete in many countries; several markets publish only season-based, hotel-based, or partial-year series; and comparability across “tourists,” “visitors,” “foreign arrivals,” and “guests” is imperfect. Those limitations do not change the broad conclusion that Africa’s tourism growth is real and materially strong. They do mean that policymakers and investors should read cross-country league tables cautiously and pay close attention to how each country counts. ⁷⁰

Annotated bibliography

UN Tourism ²⁰ , World Tourism Barometer and data portal.

The best continent-level source for recovery, regional comparisons, and 2025 direction of travel. It is indispensable for Africa-wide trend framing, though country detail is still stronger in national statistical releases than in the barometer summaries. ⁷¹

World Bank ⁷² and country statistical systems.

Useful as a harmonized long-run baseline, especially where national tourism releases are sparse, though many tourism-arrivals series lag recent years. Best used for structural context rather than the absolute latest ranking. ⁷³

Kenya Tourism Research Institute, Tourism Sector Performance Report 2024.

Strong on arrivals, source markets, and official sector framing. One of the better sub-Saharan African tourism reporting systems for practical market analysis. ⁷⁴

Tanzania Tourism Sector Survey 2024 and Bank of Tanzania travel figures.

A particularly useful source because it ties visitor counts to earnings and purpose/source-market patterns, helping distinguish volume from value. ³⁶

Statistics Mauritius, Handbook of Statistical Data on Tourism 2024 and 2025 indicators.

Exemplary tourism statistics: market mix, occupancy, earnings, and seasonality are all presented clearly. Mauritius remains one of the easiest African destinations to analyze rigorously with official data. ⁷⁵

South Africa national tourism monthly analyses and annual performance documents.

Among the richest public tourism data ecosystems in Africa, with monthly arrivals analysis, regional origin splits, and labor/output framing. Essential for understanding both recovery and market structure. ⁷⁶

Botswana International Visitor Arrivals Stats Brief 2023.

A very useful reminder that Southern African tourism cannot be understood only through long-haul leisure. The report shows the scale of regional and transit-linked travel and is therefore critical for correct interpretation of Botswana's market. ⁷⁷

Rwanda Development Board annual reporting and tourism briefings.

Especially valuable on revenue, gorilla tourism, and MICE, which makes Rwanda one of the clearest cases of a deliberately high-yield tourism model in Africa. ⁷⁸

IGAD Sustainable Tourism Master Plan 2024–2034.

One of the better regional planning documents on sustainable tourism, destination development, and coordination challenges in the Horn and eastern belt. Helpful for policy implications beyond country case studies. ⁷⁹

OECD, *Building Strong and Resilient Tourism Destinations*; Hermann 2025 on sustainable tourism in Africa; Tichaawa et al. 2024 on transfrontier conservation areas; Gumbo 2025 on nature-based tourism and wildlife conservation.

Taken together, these are the most useful cross-cutting analytical references for this report. They support

the view that Africa's next tourism phase depends less on raw arrivals growth and more on resilience, conservation governance, community linkage, and sound destination management. ⁸⁰

¹ ⁷¹ <https://atta.travel/resource/un-tourism-africa-sees-9-growth-in-international-arrivals-in-q1-2025.html>
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